SPLITSTREAM

COOPERATIVE TIMELINE HEIST — GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

PLAYERS: 1 – 4 Players **FORMAT:** Parallel Real-Time Session **OBJECTIVE:** Shared Economic Target

1. CORE CONCEPT

Splitstream is a cooperative heist game built around two parallel timelines running simultaneously in a single session. One map is set in the past, one in the future — the exact same location in two different eras. For instance, a session could take place across a 2020 bank and a 2050 science lab built on the very same site.

Both teams are robbing the same location decades apart. Neither team acts as support staff; both are executing a full, high-stakes heist concurrently.

2. THE TIMELINE LOOP

The Past team physically acts on their map, executing traditional heist maneuvers: stealing, hacking, picking locks, and taking out guards. The Future team executes the same tasks on their own map, but operates under a critical paradigm: **they cannot change history—they can only study it.**

The Future map exists as a direct consequence of everything the Past team does. Future players experience these historical ripples and structural reconfigurations in real time while pursuing their own objectives. This creates a continuous, active feedback loop:

> **1. Past Acts:** The Past team alters the environment or triggers alarms.
>
> **2. Scores Shift & Reconfigure:** Invisible metrics shift, immediately restructuring the Future map.
>
> **3. Future Analyzes:** The Future team notices environmental shifts, gathers fresh intelligence, and radios it back.
>
> **4. Past Adapts:** The Past team alters their route or strategy based on future foresight, continuing the cycle.

This communication and adaptation run continuously for the entire session with absolutely no pauses and no resets.

OPERATIONAL EXAMPLE: THE SHIFTING TARGET

*The Future team checks their archive computer at the start of the heist. It indicates that their target is linked to **Computer 1** on the Past map—if Past hacks that terminal, critical data becomes accessible in the future. The Past team moves toward Computer 1. Along the way, they make messy choices: a guard gets killed, a camera gets triggered, and a door is forced open.*

*Because of these actions, the underlying scores shift and the Future map reconfigures. The Future team checks the archive again; it now points to **Computer 12**. Future quickly radios Past: "Abort Computer 1, reroute to Computer 12!" Past must instantly adapt their route. If Past had played cleanly, the archive target would have remained stable. Because they played messily, the target re-routed. Intel is never final because Past is always acting.*

3. VICTORY CONDITIONS & THE ECONOMY

The primary objective is to collect a total of `€50,000` in value spread across both timelines. All secured loot feeds into a single, shared pool. Each map has its own independent sources of wealth, allowing players to reach the target through total flexibility: entirely from the Past, entirely from the Future, or via any blended combination.

Temporal Preservation (Delayed Gratification)

Some loot exists simultaneously in both eras. For example, a diamond necklace inside a vault in the 2020 bank can be stolen immediately by the Past team. Alternatively, they can choose to leave it untouched. If left alone, it persists into the 2050 science lab as a preserved historical artifact, re-appraised at a significantly higher valuation. Teams must dynamically coordinate whether to take immediate liquid capital or preserve items to secure a larger payout later.

4. PLAYER ALLOCATION & SCALING

Players can distribute themselves across the timelines in any configuration: two and two, three and one, or all four on one side.

- **Solo & Concentrated Play:** If all players choose to enter a single timeline, there are no active time mechanics. The game functions cleanly as a straightforward, cooperative tactical heist.
- **No Time Limits:** There is no artificial countdown timer. The tension is driven entirely by the escalation of the maps and the volatility of the temporal loop.

5. THE MECHANICS: INVISIBLE SCORE AXES

The game tracks player behavior across four hidden behavioral metrics fed exclusively by illegal actions on the Past map. Players never see these scores as numeric values or UI meters; instead, they observe physical, systemic changes reconfiguring the Future map in real time.

SCORE AXIS	PAST TRIGGERS (CAUSE)	FUTURE CONSEQUENCES (EFFECT)
Personnel	Killing guards, physical confrontations.	Alters staffing levels, guard patrol routes, and response team composition in the future.
Security	Triggering cameras, sloppy hacking, tripping sensors.	Upgrades automated defense systems, firewall complexity, and lock types.
Infrastructure	Breaking locks, cutting wires, structural sabotage.	Causes architectural shifts, structural decay, rerouted power grids, or closed entryways.
Stealth	Being spotted, entering restricted zones, leaving evidence.	Heightens general alertness, modifies available intel pathways, and changes archive data locations.

By acting consistently, players indirectly steer these scores to shape a specific archetype of the Future map, allowing them to tailor the environment to their preferred playstyle.

6. ARCHITECTURAL WORLD LAYERS

The game world is built upon two distinct operational frameworks:

1. **The Static Layer:** A rock-solid foundation of predictable cause-and-effect rules. These are concrete laws that players learn once, master, and confidently rely upon throughout every playthrough.
2. **The Dynamic Layer:** The loop itself. This layer ensures that the Future map is never the same twice, rendering it a living, breathing product of how the Past team fought, sneaked, or blundered their way to the objective.